

Becoming the **B.E.S.T.** Writer: *Writing Paragraphs*

You will start the writing process by developing an outline and/or annotated bibliography to give your writing a cohesive and logical structure. Next in the process is actually drafting your paragraphs...and this strategy for writing a paragraph will help you learn to write in an efficient and effective way.

B =

Big Idea

What's the big idea??? Every paragraph should have one big idea or thematic topic. If your paragraphs include several big ideas...it will be too difficult to keep the paragraph succinct and clear. Separate your paragraphs so that each one has only one big idea. The idea behind a paragraph is to introduce one big idea and then expand upon it with evidence and support.

E =

Examples/Evidence

Your big idea needs support, either in the form of evidence that buttresses your argument or examples that explain your idea. If you don't have any evidence or examples to support your main idea, your idea may not be strong enough to warrant a complete paragraph. In this case, re-evaluate your idea and see whether you need even to keep it in the paper.

S =

Synthesis

Your readers want to see evidence or examples related to your big idea. But merely presenting what others say is not graduate-level writing. The real "meat" of your paragraph is your interpretation of your evidence or examples: how you break them apart, compare and contrast your examples to other evidence or ideas, etc. (this is otherwise known as analysis!).

But, to truly synthesize, you need to utilize your analysis to then build your own arguments and conclusions. This is the fun and creative part...making meaning out of your research, and applying it to what you are learning and/or applying.

Tip: Always follow a citation with your own **analysis**, and integrate it into your synthesis for the paragraph...why is the citation important, how does it relate to your "Big Idea"? If you let a quote stand on its own, then the author of that quote will have a stronger voice in your paragraph (and maybe even your paper) than you will.

T =

Tie-In

Tie-ins help your reader to see how your paragraphs, and/or your whole paper fits together. When you end a paragraph, try to tie it something else in your paper, such as your paper's main thesis (or argument), the previous paragraph, or the next paragraph to come in your paper. Creating tie-ins will help your reader understand the purpose of your paragraph, and the logic and structure of your paper.

Becoming the BEST Writer: *Analyzing Paragraphs*

BEST writing concepts not only help you write great paragraphs, this method can help you quickly dissect and analyze other's writing as well.

Review the following paragraph, from "Publication, publication," by Gary King (2006).

"The broader scientific community both collectively and in many other individual fields is also moving strongly in the direction of participating in or requiring some form of data sharing. Recipients of grants from the National Science Foundation and the National Institutes of Health now are required to make data available to other scholars upon publication or within a year of the termination of their grant (National Institutes of Health, 2006). Replicating, and thus collectively and publicly validating, the integrity of our published work is often still more difficult than it should be, and some still oppose the whole idea. However, our discipline, in particular, has made substantial progress."

Now, let's use BEST Writer to analyze it: Can you identify the Big Idea, the Evidence, the Synthesis, and the Tie-In? Scroll down to see the breakdown.

BIG Idea	The broader scientific community both collectively and in many other individual fields is also moving strongly in the direction of participating in or requiring some form of data sharing.
Evidence	Recipients of grants from the National Science Foundation and the National Institutes of Health now are required to make data available to other scholars upon publication or within a year of the termination of their grant (National Institutes of Health, 2006).
Synthesis	Replicating, and thus collectively and publicly validating, the integrity of our published work is often still more difficult than it should be, and some still oppose the whole idea.
Tie-in	However, our discipline, in particular, has made substantial progress.

A couple of items to note:

1. At a minimum, your paragraph will have 3-4 sentences, but most paragraphs will contain two or three evidence components and can be much longer.
2. King's next paragraph discusses the progression of the "replication debate."

Example from: King, Gary. (2006). Publication, publication. PS: Political Science and Politics, 39.1, 119-125. Retrieved December 7, 2006 from <http://gking.harvard.edu/files/abs/paperspub-abs.shtml>.